TRANSACTIONAL ANALYSIS

A beginner-friendly guide to workplace communication

Definitions • Plain-English explanations • Short examples • TA Coach reference

How to use this guide

Read the sections in order. You do not need to memorise every label immediately. First ask what each person might be trying to communicate, then notice how one message affects the next response, and finally consider a more constructive reply.

Important: Transactional Analysis (TA) is a framework for reflecting on communication, not a tool for diagnosing personality. A short sentence alone rarely proves an ego state; context, tone and relationship matter.

1. What is Transactional Analysis (TA)?

Transactional Analysis is a psychological and communication framework associated with psychiatrist Eric Berne. It helps people notice patterns in how they communicate, respond to others, seek recognition and handle conflict.

In simple words: TA helps us ask, "What kind of communication is happening here, and how could I respond more constructively?"

Example: A manager asks, "The report is late. What happened?" The employee can respond defensively ("You never give clear instructions!") or calmly explain the blocker and agree on a recovery plan. TA gives us language to examine these exchanges.

2. Ego states: Parent, Adult and Child

An ego state is a pattern of thinking, feeling and behaving in a moment. These are not fixed personality types or age groups. Everyone can show different ego states at different times, and none is automatically good or bad.

Ego state	Plain-English meaning	Possible clues	Workplace example
Parent	Learned rules, values, protection or judgement.	"You should…", rules, advice, reassurance.	"Please follow the safety checklist before releasing the build."
Adult	Present facts, options and practical decisions.	Questions, evidence, clarification, planning.	"The test failed twice. Let's check the logs and decide the fix."
Child	Feelings, spontaneity, adaptation or resistance learned earlier in life.	Excitement, fear, playful ideas, "It's not fair!", compliance.	"I'm nervous about presenting, but I'll practise and try."

Useful subtypes

• Critical/Controlling Parent: sets rules or judges. Example: "You always make careless mistakes." It can enforce standards but may become blaming.

• Nurturing Parent: supports, protects or reassures. Example: "Take a breath; I can help you work through this."

• Free Child: expresses spontaneity, playfulness or creativity. Example: "Let's try a bold new idea!"

• Adapted Child: adjusts to expectations, cooperatively or rebelliously. Example: "Okay, I'll do it your way," or "You can't make me."

These labels are interpretations, not facts. "You should send the report today" could be practical guidance or controlling criticism depending on tone and context.

3. Transactions: how messages connect

A transaction is an exchange: one person sends a message and another responds. TA looks at the pattern between the messages, not just at individual sentences.

3.1 Complementary transaction

The response comes from the ego state the first message appears to address, so the conversation can continue smoothly.

Example: Manager: "Can you send the updated file by 3 PM?" Employee: "Yes. I'll send it by 2:30 PM."

3.2 Crossed transaction
The response comes from an unexpected direction, often creating confusion or conflict.

Example: Manager: “Why is the file late?” Employee: “You always blame me!” The manager asked for an explanation but received a personal counterattack.

3.3 Ulterior transaction
A message carries two layers: an obvious social message and a less direct psychological message. Do not assume you know the hidden meaning without context.

Example: A colleague says pointedly, “Some people actually manage to submit work on time.” The literal message is about punctuality; the implied message may be criticism directed at someone.

Memory trick: complementary = response fits; crossed = response goes in an unexpected direction; ulterior = possible second, hidden layer.

4. Strokes: recognition and acknowledgement
A stroke is a unit of recognition or acknowledgement. People often want to feel seen, noticed and valued. Strokes can be verbal or non-verbal, positive or negative, and conditional or unconditional.

• Positive stroke: appreciation. Example: “Your summary made the decision much clearer.”

• Negative stroke: criticism or disapproval. Example: “This version misses the required data.” Specific, respectful correction can help; insults do not.

• Conditional stroke: recognition for something a person does. Example: “You handled the client escalation well.”

• Unconditional stroke: acknowledgement of the person. Example: “I value having you on this team.”

Workplace lesson: Give specific, sincere recognition. When correcting, focus on the work and next step rather than attacking the person.

5. Listening and reflective communication
Active listening means trying to understand the other person before preparing your reply. Reflective communication makes that understanding visible by paraphrasing, checking meaning and acknowledging relevant feelings.

• Paraphrasing: restating the main point. Example: “So the delay happened because you were waiting for the sales figures—is that right?”

• Clarifying question: asking for missing information. Example: “When do you expect the figures, and what can we send before then?”

• Acknowledging feelings: recognising an emotion without agreeing with every claim. Example: “I can see the last-minute change has been frustrating.”

• Open question: invites explanation. Example: “What is the biggest blocker right now?”

Listening does not mean agreeing with everything. It means understanding accurately before deciding what to do.

6. Games People Play
In TA, a psychological game is a recurring interaction pattern that tends to produce predictable frustration, blame or discomfort. It is more than a one-off disagreement; it is a framework for noticing patterns, not a label to use against colleagues.

Example: A teammate repeatedly says, “Nobody helps me.” When someone offers help, they reject every suggestion and later say, “See, nobody can help.” Both sides end frustrated.

How to interrupt it: Describe the observable problem, ask what specific help is wanted, agree on a concrete next step, and avoid guessing hidden motives.

Alternative response: “I want to help. Which one task would be most useful for me to take on today?”

7. Life scripts
A life script is a broad TA idea for a story or set of expectations a person may have learned about themselves, other people and what is possible. These expectations can influence behaviour, but they are not destiny.

Example: Someone thinks, “If I ask a question, people will think I’m incompetent,” and stays silent in meetings even when clarification would help.

Constructive reframe: “A precise question can prevent rework and show responsibility.”

For TA Coach, treat script-like beliefs as tentative reflections only. Do not claim to know someone's childhood or personal history.

8. Assertiveness, passivity and aggression

Style	Meaning	Example
Passive	Does not state needs or boundaries; may agree despite concerns.	"It's fine, I'll do both tasks," even though the workload is impossible.
Aggressive	Pushes own needs while dismissing or attacking others.	"Your planning is useless. Fix this now."
Assertive	States needs and boundaries clearly while respecting others.	"I can finish by Friday. To finish today, I'll need help with the data."

Simple assertiveness formula: State the situation + explain the impact or need + make a clear request.

Example: "The figures have not arrived, so the report is blocked. Could you share them by noon or confirm an alternative source?"

9. Discounting

Discounting is treating an important part of a problem as if it does not matter, does not exist or cannot be changed. In TA, it can prevent realistic problem-solving.

- Discounting the problem: "The repeated data errors are no big deal."
- Discounting a solution: "There is no point adding a validation check; it won't help."
- Discounting one's options or ability: "I can't ask anyone for clarification."

More useful response: "The errors are recurring. Let's measure how often they occur, identify the cause and test a preventive check."

10. Problem-solving through a fact-based conversation

A practical sequence is to separate facts from assumptions, define the problem, explore options, agree on action and review the result.

- Facts: What do we know? What is uncertain?
- Problem: What exactly is blocked or not meeting expectations?
- Options: What are two or three possible ways forward?
- Agreement: Who will do what, and by when?
- Review: How will we know whether the solution worked?

Example: Instead of "You never send data on time," say: "The last two reports were delayed because the figures arrived after noon. Can we agree on a 10 AM hand-off or an escalation contact?"

11. Negotiation and conflict resolution

Negotiation is a conversation to reach an agreement when people have different needs or preferences. Conflict resolution means addressing a disagreement and finding a workable way forward.

- Position: what someone says they want. Example: "I need the report today."
- Interest: why they want it. Example: "The client review is tomorrow."
- Options: possible ways to meet the interests. Example: send a reliable draft today and the validated appendix tomorrow.
- Agreement: the specific commitment both parties accept.

Useful question: "What is the essential outcome you need today, and what could be delivered tomorrow?"

TA connection: notice whether the exchange is becoming blaming or defensive, then return to facts, needs, options and commitments.

12. Influence and persuasion

Influence is the ability to affect how another person thinks or acts. Persuasion is a deliberate attempt to gain support for an idea or action. Constructive influence uses relevant evidence, empathy and a clear request—not pressure or manipulation.

Example: Instead of "You must use my dashboard," say, "The dashboard highlights failed VMs and may reduce manual checks. Can we pilot it for two weeks and compare time saved?"

- Make the benefit relevant to the listener.
- Support claims with evidence or a small test.

- Invite questions and objections.
- Be transparent about trade-offs and uncertainty.

13. Self-disclosure

Self-disclosure means sharing relevant information about your thoughts, feelings, experiences or needs. It can build trust when it fits the relationship and setting.

Example: “I’m still learning this reporting tool, so I’d appreciate feedback on whether the dashboard is clear.”

Share honestly, keep it relevant, respect privacy and do not pressure others to reveal personal information.

14. Group dynamics

Group dynamics are patterns of interaction within a team: who speaks, who is heard, how decisions are made, how disagreement is handled and how responsibility is shared.

- Dominance: one or two voices take most of the airtime.
- Conformity: members agree publicly to avoid standing out, even if they have concerns.
- Groupthink: the group values agreement so strongly that it fails to examine alternatives or risks.
- Psychological safety: people feel able to ask questions, disagree respectfully and admit mistakes without humiliation.

Example: A leader asks each person for one risk before making a decision. This can surface concerns that quieter members might otherwise withhold.

15. Ethics in communication

Ethical communication is truthful, respectful, fair and mindful of privacy and consequences.

- Accuracy: do not invent facts or overstate certainty.
- Respect: critique actions or ideas without humiliating people.
- Confidentiality: share sensitive information only with authorised people.
- Transparency: make requests and intentions clear.
- Fairness: allow relevant perspectives to be heard.

Example: When summarising a disagreement, represent both positions accurately instead of editing the summary to make one colleague look bad.

16. TA contracts

A contract in TA is an explicit agreement about the goal of an interaction or intervention, the roles of the people involved and what each person will do. It keeps expectations clear and shared.

Example: Student and coach agree: “We will practise giving constructive feedback for 10 minutes. The coach will play a colleague, and afterwards we will review clarity, listening and problem-solving.”

- Goal: What are we trying to achieve?
- Roles: Who is responsible for what?
- Boundaries: What is in scope, and what is not?
- Completion: How will we know the agreed task is done?

17. Worked workplace example

Situation: A report is late because the employee is waiting for sales figures.

Manager: “The report is late again. Why didn’t you tell me?”

Employee, defensive response: “You always blame me! Sales never sends the data on time.”

What might be happening?

- The manager may be expressing frustration through a critical Parent-like message; this is only a possible reading.
- The employee's reply may be defensive or blaming, crossing the request for an explanation and increasing friction.
- The exchange has moved away from solving the practical problem.

More constructive response: “I should have flagged the delay earlier. I’m waiting for the sales figures. I’ll send the completed sections now and contact Sales for an ETA. If the figures are not available by noon, I’ll share an estimate clearly marked as provisional.”

Why it is better: it acknowledges responsibility, states the blocker, proposes actions and sets a contingency. It uses Adult-like problem-solving without requiring TA jargon.

18. How to analyse a conversation for TA Coach

• Read the full exchange before assigning labels.

• Identify observable words and actions first; do not guess at motives.

• Suggest possible ego-state cues only when the text supports them.

• Classify the transaction as complementary, crossed, ulterior or unclear, with a short explanation.

• Look for listening, assertiveness, conflict management and practical problem-solving.

• Give one specific strength, one improvement and one alternative response.

• Use cautious language: “may suggest,” “could be read as,” or “the text is insufficient.”

Better analysis: Rather than “The employee is in Child,” say, “The phrase ‘You always blame me’ may indicate a defensive response; tone and context would be needed for a confident interpretation.”

19. Quick glossary

Term	Plain-English meaning
Ego state	A pattern of thinking, feeling and behaving in a moment.
Parent / Adult / Child	Three broad ego-state categories for reflecting on communication.
Transaction	A message and the response it receives.
Complementary	The response fits the direction of the initial message.
Crossed	The response comes from an unexpected direction and may cause friction.
Ulterior	A communication with a possible hidden layer beneath the literal message.
Stroke	Recognition or acknowledgement.
Psychological game	A recurring interaction pattern that tends to end in predictable frustration.
Life script	A learned story or expectation that may influence behaviour.
Assertiveness	Expressing needs clearly while respecting others.
Discounting	Minimising a problem, solution or available ability/options.
Self-disclosure	Sharing relevant information about oneself.
Group dynamics	Patterns of interaction and influence within a group.
TA contract	An explicit agreement about a goal, roles and actions.

20. Mini self-check

1. A colleague asks, “Can you explain the delay?” You reply, “The data arrived at 2 PM; I can send the draft now.” What style does the reply mainly show?

Answer: Adult-like: facts and a practical next step.

2. What is the difference between crossed and ulterior transactions?

Answer: Crossed: the response goes in an unexpected direction. Ulterior: the exchange may carry both a literal and a hidden message.

3. Is the Parent ego state always negative?

Answer: No. It can be caring and supportive or critical and controlling.

4. What is an assertive way to handle an impossible deadline?

Answer: State the constraint, explain the impact and request a priority decision or resource.

5. Should an AI confidently infer someone's life script from one sentence?

Answer: No. It should avoid unsupported conclusions and treat interpretations as tentative.

Final takeaway

The practical purpose of TA is not to label people as Parent, Adult or Child. It is to notice communication patterns, understand how responses affect the exchange, and choose a clearer, more respectful and more useful next message. For TA Coach, labels and scores should be learning feedback—not clinical judgements or official grades.